Chapter 15 — Observability and Production

Everything so far has been about making the application *work*. This chapter is about keeping it working once real users depend on it: knowing whether it is healthy, how fast it is, which request failed and why, shutting it down without dropping requests, and starting it quickly in **containers** (isolated, lightweight packages that hold an app plus everything it needs to run, started by Docker or Kubernetes). Spring Boot's answer is a set of "production-ready features": **Actuator** (management endpoints), **Micrometer** (metrics and the Observation API), **Micrometer Tracing + OpenTelemetry** (distributed tracing: following one request across several services), **structured logging**, graceful shutdown (finishing in-flight requests before stopping), virtual threads, and faster startup with AOT (ahead-of-time) caches and native images (§15.11).

What you'll learn

1. The three pillars of observability — logs, metrics, traces — and how Spring connects them.
2. Actuator: endpoints, exposure, access control and securing them.
3. Health: indicators, groups, Kubernetes liveness/readiness probes (on by default in Boot 4), writing a custom `HealthIndicator`.
4. `/actuator/info`: build, git, Java and environment information.
5. Micrometer metrics: `Counter`, `Timer`, `Gauge`, tags, cardinality, the Prometheus scrape format.
6. The Observation API and `@Observed`: one instrumentation, both a metric and a span.
7. Distributed tracing with the OpenTelemetry bridge: trace/span ids in logs, propagation across HTTP calls, exporters, sampling.
8. Structured JSON logging (ECS, Logstash, GELF).
9. Graceful shutdown and what happens in Kubernetes.
10. Virtual threads with one property.
11. Faster startup: extracted jars, CDS, the JDK AOT cache (measured), Spring AOT and GraalVM native images; container images with buildpacks or a Dockerfile.
12. A production configuration checklist.

The code lives in two Spring Boot 4.1.1 / Framework 7.0 projects on Java 25:

- `code/observability-demo/` — Actuator, health, metrics, Prometheus, tracing, structured logs (8 tests).
- `code/production-runtime/` — graceful shutdown and virtual threads (4 tests), plus `code/aot-cache-demo.sh` for the startup comparison.

Outputs are real `mvn -q verify` output (Maven building the projects and running their tests); Spring's log noise is trimmed as `...`.

> **Prerequisites.** Configuration properties and profiles: Chapter 3. Security filter chains: Chapter 10. `RestClient`: Chapter 6. `@ConcurrencyLimit`: 4.7. The system-design view of health checks and tracing is in Operating in Production.

15.1 Observability in one page

What it is

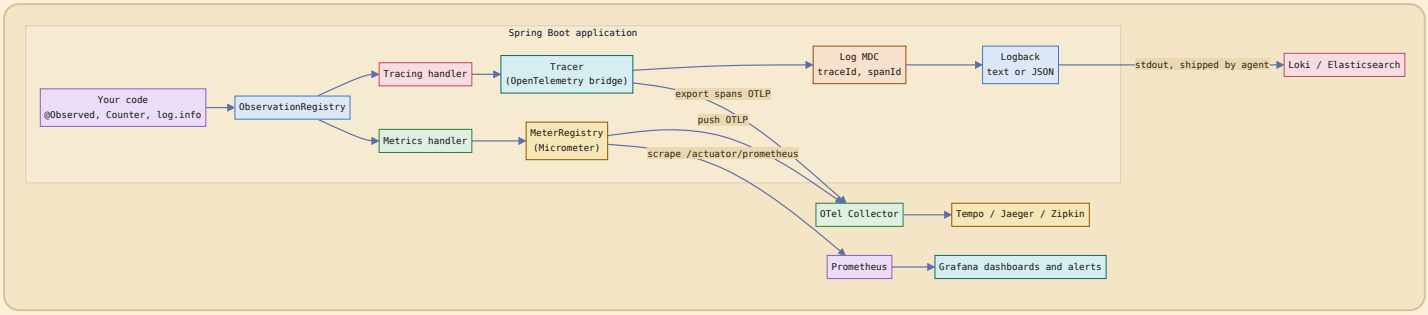
Observability is how well you can understand what a running system is doing from the outside, using the data it emits — without attaching a debugger (a tool that pauses a program so you can inspect it step by step) or adding new code. The data comes in three kinds, often called the **three pillars**:

Pillar	What it is	Answers	Spring tool
Logs	timestamped text or JSON events	"what exactly happened in this request?"	SLF4J + Logback (Java's standard logging API and Boot's default implementation of it), structured logging
Metrics	numbers aggregated over time (counts, durations, gauges)	"how many, how fast, how full — right now and as a trend?"	Micrometer `MeterRegistry`
Traces	the path of one request through many services, as a tree of timed **spans** (one span = one timed step of work, §15.7)	"where did this slow request spend its time?"	Micrometer Tracing + OpenTelemetry

Analogy: a hospital patient. The **metrics** are the monitor showing heart rate and blood pressure over time; the **logs** are the nurse's notes; the **trace** is the record of which departments the patient visited, in what order, and how long each took. You need all three: the monitor tells you *something* is wrong, the visit record tells you *where*, the notes tell you *what*.

Monitoring is the older, narrower idea: watching known metrics and alerting (sending a notification to a person) on thresholds (limits such as "error rate above 1%"). Observability adds the ability to ask new questions (e.g. "which customer's requests are slow?") from rich, correlated data.

How Spring wires it together



- **Micrometer** is a vendor-neutral **facade** (a single API in front of many interchangeable implementations) for metrics ("SLF4J for metrics"): you write to a `MeterRegistry`, and a registry implementation (Prometheus — the popular open-source metrics database, OTLP, Datadog, ...) formats and ships the numbers.
- **Micrometer Observation** is one API that produces *both* a metric and a span for a piece of work.
- **Micrometer Tracing** is a facade over a tracer. Boot 4 supports two: **OpenTelemetry** (`spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry`) and **Brave** with Zipkin (`spring-boot-starter-zipkin`).
- The tracer puts the current `traceId` and `spanId` into the logging **MDC** (Mapped Diagnostic Context, a per-thread map that log patterns can print), so every log line is linked to its trace.

Real-world examples

- Grafana's "LGTM" stack (Loki for logs, Grafana, Tempo for traces, Mimir/Prometheus for metrics) is a common open-source destination for exactly these three outputs.
- The OpenTelemetry Collector is widely deployed as a **sidecar** (a helper container that runs next to the app container in the same pod) or agent that receives OTLP (the OpenTelemetry protocol) and forwards to any **backend** (the storage and UI system where the data ends up), so apps don't hard-code the vendor.

Self-check

1. Name the three pillars and a question each answers. → Logs (what happened), metrics (how many/how fast over time), traces (where time went across services).
2. What is Micrometer? → A vendor-neutral metrics facade; you record to `MeterRegistry`, a registry implementation exports to the chosen backend.

3. How are logs linked to traces? → The tracer puts `traceId`/`spanId` in the MDC and the log pattern or JSON encoder prints them.

15.2 Spring Boot Actuator

What it is

Actuator adds **management endpoints** to your application: small built-in HTTP (or JMX — Java Management Extensions, the JVM's older built-in management protocol) APIs for operators (the people and tools that run the app in production) — health, metrics, info, loggers, environment, thread dumps (a snapshot of what every thread is doing) and more. Add `spring-boot-starter-actuator` and they appear under `/actuator`.

Analogy: the dashboard and service port of a car. Drivers (users) never see it; mechanics (operators, Kubernetes — the platform that runs and restarts containers, Prometheus) plug into it.

The endpoints

ID	Shows / does	Notes
`health`	UP/DOWN status, components, probes	the only endpoint exposed over HTTP by default
`info`	build, git, Java, custom `info.*` properties	contributors switched on by properties
`metrics`	list of meters; `/metrics/{name}` for one	JSON, for humans
`prometheus`	all meters in Prometheus text format	needs `micrometer-registry-prometheus`
`loggers`	view and **change** log levels at runtime	`POST /actuator/loggers/com.acme` `{"configuredLevel":"DEBUG"}`
`env`, `configprops`	resolved properties, `@ConfigurationProperties` beans	values masked by default (`show-values=never`)
`beans`, `conditions`, `mappings`	beans, auto-configuration report, request mappings	great for debugging (Chapter 3)
`threaddump`, `heapdump`	JVM thread dump, heap dump file (a copy of every object in memory)	heap dumps can contain secrets — protect them
`httpexchanges`	recent requests/responses	needs an `HttpExchangeRepository` bean
`scheduledtasks`, `caches`, `flyway`, `liquibase`, `quartz`, `sessions`	feature-specific	appear when the feature is present
`startup`	startup steps and their duration	needs `BufferingApplicationStartup`
`shutdown`	shuts the app down	access `none` by default

Exposure vs access

Two separate switches decide whether an endpoint can be called:

1. **Access** (since Boot 3.4, replacing the older `enabled` flags): is the endpoint allowed at all, and may it change things? Values `none`, `read-only`, `unrestricted`.
2. **Exposure**: is it reachable over **HTTP** or **JMX**? By default only `health` is exposed on both.

```
# expose more endpoints over HTTP ("*" = all; quote it in YAML)
management.endpoints.web.exposure.include=health,info,metrics,prometheus,env,loggers
management.endpoints.web.exposure.exclude=heapdump

# access control
management.endpoint.loggers.access=read-only        # can read levels, cannot change them
management.endpoints.access.default=none            # opt-in style: everything off ...
management.endpoint.health.access=read-only         # ... except what you list
management.endpoints.access.max-permitted=read-only # hard ceiling for the whole app

# a separate port (and optionally address) for all management endpoints
management.server.port=8081
management.endpoints.web.base-path=/manage          # default /actuator
```

A separate **management port** is common in Kubernetes: the public **ingress** (Kubernetes' entry point for traffic from outside the cluster) only routes to 8080, while probes and Prometheus reach 8081 inside the cluster.

Securing actuator endpoints

If Spring Security is on the classpath (the set of libraries the app loads), you decide who can call what with `EndpointRequest` matchers. In Boot 4 the class moved to `org.springframework.boot.security.autoconfigure.actuate.web.servlet.EndpointRequest` (it was `org.springframework.boot.actuate.autoconfigure.security.servlet` in Boot 3).

```
@Bean
SecurityFilterChain security(HttpSecurity http) throws Exception {
    http.authorizeHttpRequests(auth -> auth
            // probes, info and the Prometheus scrape stay open (normally reachable only inside the cluster)
            .requestMatchers(EndpointRequest.to("health", "info", "prometheus")).permitAll()
            // every other actuator endpoint needs the OPS role
            .requestMatchers(EndpointRequest.toAnyEndpoint()).hasRole("OPS")
            .anyRequest().permitAll())
        .httpBasic(Customizer.withDefaults())
        .csrf(csrf -> csrf.disable());   // demo API only; see chapter 10 for CSRF
    return http.build();
}
```

`EndpointRequest` matches by endpoint **ID**, so it keeps working if you change the base path or the management port. The test (`ActuatorEndpointsTests`) proves both sides:

```
anonymous /actuator/env -> 401, ops /actuator/loggers/ch15.obs -> {"effectiveLevel":"INFO"}
```

Common mistakes

- `management.endpoints.web.exposure.include=*` on a public port without security: `env`, `heapdump` and `threaddump` can leak secrets and internals. Expose the minimum; protect the rest.
- Thinking exposure is enough — an endpoint with access `none` stays unavailable even when exposed.
- Forgetting that `health` details (`show-details`) can reveal hostnames, disk paths and versions (you will see a disk path in the output below).

Self-check

1. Which endpoints are exposed over HTTP by default? → Only `health`.
2. Difference between exposure and access? → Access decides if the endpoint exists and whether it may write; exposure decides whether HTTP/JMX can reach it.
3. Why a separate management port? → Keep operational endpoints off the public ingress while probes and scrapers reach them internally.

15.3 Health, health groups and Kubernetes probes

What it is

The `health` endpoint aggregates **health indicators** — small checks such as "can I reach the database?" or "is there disk space?" — into one status. Status values are `UP`, `DOWN`, `OUT_OF_SERVICE` and `UNKNOWN`; the overall status is the "worst" one (default order: `DOWN`, `OUT_OF_SERVICE`, `UP`, `UNKNOWN`). `DOWN` and `OUT_OF_SERVICE` are returned with HTTP **503**, others with 200.

Auto-configured indicators appear when their technology is present: `ping`, `diskSpace`, `db` (a `DataSource`), `redis`, `mongo`, `rabbit`, `mail`, `ssl` (certificate validity), `livenessState`, `readinessState`, and more.

Why it matters

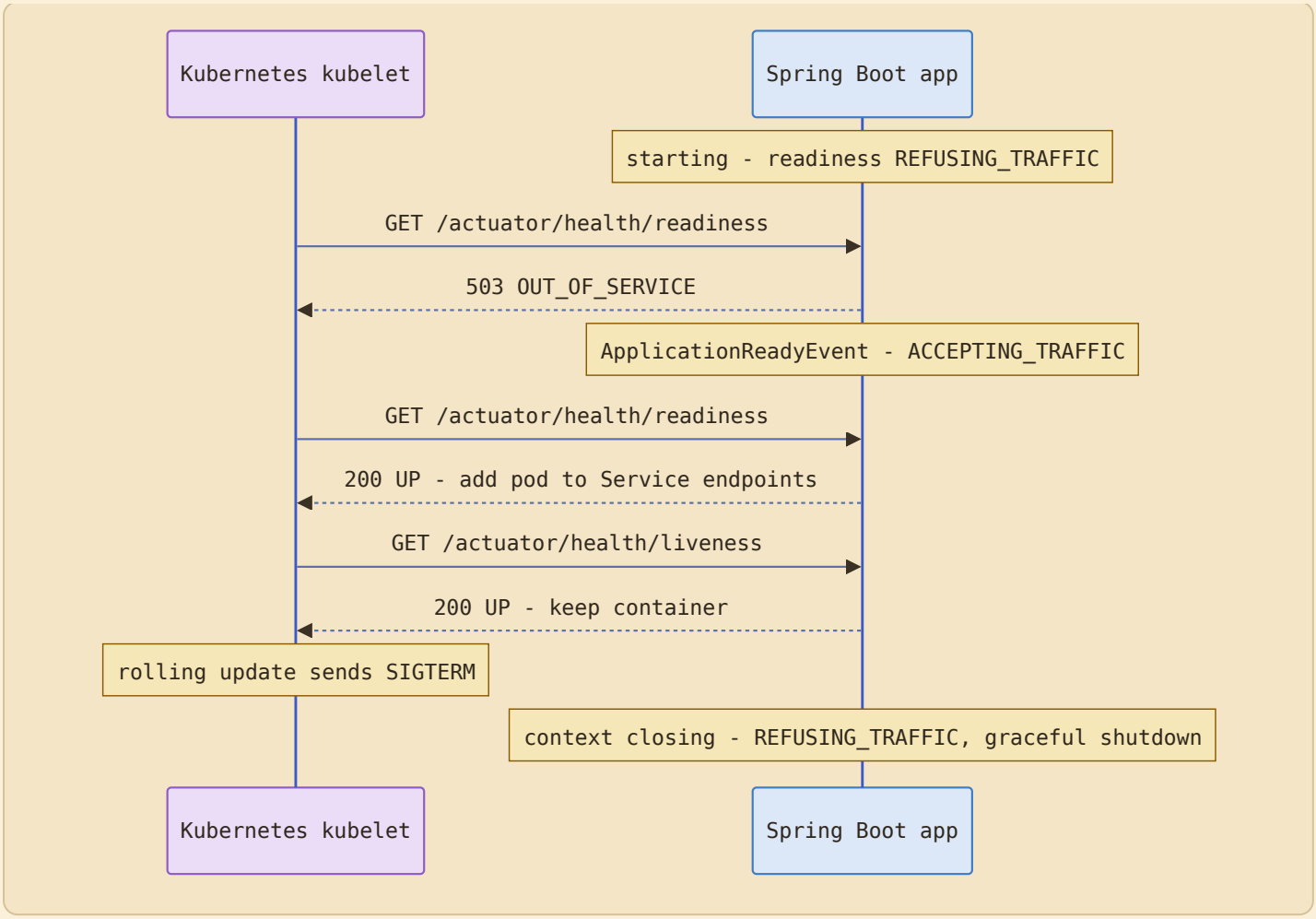
Load balancers (components that spread requests over instances) and **orchestrators** (platforms such as Kubernetes that start, stop and move containers) make decisions from these answers: take an instance out of rotation (stop sending it requests), restart a container, stop a **rolling deployment** (replacing instances with the new version a few at a time). See System Design Fundamentals. A wrong health design can **cause** outages (periods when the service is unavailable): if every instance reports DOWN because one optional dependency is slow, the platform removes all of them.

Liveness vs readiness

Kubernetes asks two different questions:

Probe	Question	On failure Kubernetes...	Should include
Liveness	"Is this process broken beyond repair?"	**restarts** the container	only internal state (deadlock — threads stuck waiting for each other forever, corrupted state) — never external systems
Readiness	"Can this instance serve traffic right now?"	**stops routing** traffic to it (no restart)	warming up, shutting down, and — carefully — dependencies it cannot work without
Startup (K8s only)	"Has it finished starting?"	holds off the other probes	usually point it at the liveness endpoint with a larger threshold

Spring Boot tracks two **availability states** for you: `LivenessState` (`CORRECT` / `BROKEN`) and `ReadinessState` (`ACCEPTING_TRAFFIC` / `REFUSING_TRAFFIC`). Boot marks the app ready only after startup (including `CommandLineRunner`s) has finished, and switches readiness to `REFUSING_TRAFFIC` when the application context starts closing. **In Boot 4 the probe groups are enabled by default** — `/actuator/health/liveness` and `/actuator/health/readiness` exist without any configuration (in Boot 2.3–3.x they were enabled automatically only on Kubernetes, or with `management.endpoint.health.probes.enabled=true`).



A custom `HealthIndicator`

In Boot 4 the health API moved to its own module: `org.springframework.boot.health.contributor.HealthIndicator` and `Health` (Boot 3: `org.springframework.boot.actuate.health`).

```
// Bean name "inventoryHealthIndicator" -> health component name "inventory"
@Component
public class InventoryHealthIndicator implements HealthIndicator {

    private final InventoryStatus status;   // pretend connection state, flipped by the tests

    public InventoryHealthIndicator(InventoryStatus status) {
        this.status = status;
    }

    @Override
    public Health health() {
        if (status.reachable()) {
            return Health.up().withDetail("latencyMs", 12).build();
        }
        return Health.down().withDetail("error", "inventory service not reachable").build();
    }
}
```

Keep `health()` **fast and cheap** — it runs on every probe (typically every 5–10 s per instance). For slow checks, cache the last result or compute it in the background. For reactive apps implement `ReactiveHealthIndicator`.

Health groups

A **group** is a named subset of indicators with its own settings, served at `/actuator/health/{group}`. Liveness and readiness are just two built-in groups.

```
management.endpoint.health.show-details=when-authorized     # never | when-authorized | always
management.endpoint.health.roles=OPS
# a custom group, e.g. for a deployment smoke check
management.endpoint.health.group.deploy.include=ping,inventory
management.endpoint.health.group.deploy.show-details=always
# readiness also fails when inventory is down (a deliberate choice - see Trade-offs)
management.endpoint.health.group.readiness.include=readinessState,inventory
```

Other group options: `exclude`, `status.order`, `status.http-mapping.*`, `additional-path` (serve the group on the main port, e.g. `server:/healthz`). `management.endpoint.health.probes.add-additional-paths=true` also serves `/livez` and `/readyz` on the main server port.

Proof

The tests call the endpoints anonymously and as the `ops` user, then make "inventory" unreachable:

```
anonymous /actuator/health -> {"groups":["deploy","liveness","readiness"],"status":"UP"}
ops       /actuator/health -> {"components":{"diskSpace":{"details":
{"total":494384795648,"free":63519252480,"threshold":10485760,"path":".../observability-
demo/.","exists":true},"status":"UP"},"inventory":{"details":{"latencyMs":12},"status":"UP"},"livenessState":
{"status":"UP"},"ping":{"status":"UP"},"readinessState":{"status":"UP"},"ssl":{"details":{"expiringChains":
[],"invalidChains":[],"validChains":[]},"status":"UP"}},"groups":["deploy","liveness","readiness"],"status":"UP"}
inventory reachable:
  liveness  -> {"status":"UP"}
  readiness -> {"status":"UP"}
inventory DOWN:
  liveness  -> {"status":"UP"}
  readiness -> {"status":"DOWN"} (HTTP 503)
  deploy    -> {"components":{"inventory":{"details":{"error":"inventory service not
reachable"},"status":"DOWN"},"ping":{"status":"UP"}},"status":"DOWN"} (HTTP 503)
```

Things to notice:

- Anonymous callers get only the status and the group names — details need the `OPS` role (`when-authorized`).
- The `liveness` group exists though we never configured it: probes are on by default in Boot 4.
- Liveness stays UP while a dependency is down — restarting our container would not fix the inventory service.

The application can also change its own state, for example to drain traffic before maintenance:

```
AvailabilityChangeEvent.publish(context, ReadinessState.REFUSING_TRAFFIC);
```

```
after REFUSING_TRAFFIC: readiness -> {"status":"OUT_OF_SERVICE"} (HTTP 503)
```

Kubernetes configuration (not run here):

```
livenessProbe:
  httpGet: { path: /actuator/health/liveness, port: 8081 }
  periodSeconds: 10
  failureThreshold: 3
readinessProbe:
  httpGet: { path: /actuator/health/readiness, port: 8081 }
  periodSeconds: 5
  failureThreshold: 3
startupProbe:
  httpGet: { path: /actuator/health/liveness, port: 8081 }
  periodSeconds: 5
  failureThreshold: 30        # up to 150 s to start before liveness takes over
```

Trade-offs

Putting a dependency in **readiness** protects users from an instance that cannot serve — but if *all* instances share that dependency, all become unready at once and the service disappears entirely, even for requests that don't need it. Include a dependency in readiness only if the instance is truly

useless without it; otherwise stay ready and **degrade** (keep working with reduced features: fallbacks, cached data, circuit breakers — guards that stop calling a failing service for a while, Chapter 16).

Common mistakes

- Database check in **liveness** → a DB blip restarts every pod (a **pod** is Kubernetes' unit for one running instance), making recovery slower (a "restart storm").
- Slow indicators (calling a remote API synchronously on every probe) → probe timeouts → false failures.
- Same thresholds for liveness and readiness → a slow start gets the container killed; use a startup probe.
- `show-details=always` on a public port → leaks infrastructure details.

In the interview

Q: What's the difference between liveness and readiness, and how does Spring Boot support them? 30-second answer: Liveness asks "should the container be restarted?", readiness asks "should it receive traffic?". Boot tracks `LivenessState` and `ReadinessState`, exposes them as health groups at `/actuator/health/liveness` and `/readiness` (on by default in Boot 4), marks readiness only after startup completes and refuses traffic during shutdown. External dependencies never belong in liveness.

- *Follow-up: how do you add a custom check?* → A `HealthIndicator` bean returning `Health.up()/down().withDetail(...)`, then include it in a group if needed.
- *Follow-up: how do you take one instance out of rotation without killing it?* → Publish `AvailabilityChangeEvent` with `ReadinessState.REFUSING_TRAFFIC`.

Self-check

1. Which HTTP status does a DOWN health group return? → 503.
2. Where does a custom indicator's name come from? → The bean name minus the `HealthIndicator` suffix.
3. Why not include the database in liveness? → A restart doesn't fix the database, and restarting all pods at once worsens the outage.

TL;DR

`HealthIndicator` beans → `/actuator/health`; groups (`management.endpoint.health.group.<name>.include`) → `/actuator/health/<name>`; liveness/readiness groups are on by default in Boot 4; keep liveness internal-only, be careful with dependencies in readiness.

15.4 The info endpoint

`/actuator/info` shows descriptive facts about the running build — invaluable when you ask "which version is actually deployed?". It is assembled from **info contributors**:

Contributor	Content	Enabled by
`build`	group, artifact, version, build time	present when `META-INF/build-info.properties` exists (Maven plugin goal `build-info`)
`git`	branch, commit id and time	present when `git.properties` exists (`git-commit-id-maven-plugin`)
`env`	every `info.*` property	`management.info.env.enabled=true`
`java`	JVM and runtime vendor/version	`management.info.java.enabled=true`
`os`, `process`	OS name/version, PID (process id), CPUs, memory	`management.info.os.enabled`, `management.info.process.enabled`
custom	anything	an `InfoContributor` bean

```
<plugin>
  <groupId>org.springframework.boot</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-boot-maven-plugin</artifactId>
  <executions>
    <execution><goals><goal>build-info</goal></goals></execution>
  </executions>
</plugin>
```

```
management.info.env.enabled=true
management.info.java.enabled=true
info.app.description=Orders demo for chapter 15
```

```
/actuator/info -> {"app":{"description":"Orders demo for chapter 15"},"build":{"artifact":"ch15-observability-demo","name":"ch15-observability-demo","time":"2026-09-28T23:50:25.503Z","version":"1.0.0","group":"handbook.spring"},"java":{"jvm":{"name":"OpenJDK 64-Bit Server VM","vendor":"Homebrew","version":"25.0.2"},"runtime":{"name":"OpenJDK Runtime Environment","version":"25.0.2"},"vendor":{"name":"Homebrew","vers...
```

Never put secrets in `info.*` — the endpoint is usually public.

15.5 Metrics with Micrometer

What it is

A **metric** is a number measured repeatedly over time. Micrometer records metrics in **meters** registered in a `MeterRegistry`. Each meter has a **name** and **tags** (key/value dimensions, e.g. `status=200`) — every unique combination of name + tag values is its own **time series**.

Meter	Measures	Example	Prometheus output
`Counter`	a count that only increases	orders placed, errors	`name_total`
`Timer`	count + total time + max of short events	request latency	`name_seconds_count`, `_sum`, `_max` (+ buckets if histogram on: counts of values per range, e.g. "under 100 ms")
`Gauge`	a current value sampled when read	queue size, pool usage	`name`
`DistributionSummary`	distribution of non-time values	payload size	`name_count`, `_sum`, `_max`
`LongTaskTimer`	tasks *currently* running and for how long	a batch job in progress	`name_active_count`, `_duration_sum`

Analogy: a car. The odometer is a **counter**, the fuel needle a **gauge**, the lap-time stopwatch a **timer**.

What Boot gives you for free

With Actuator on the classpath, Boot registers JVM memory/GC/threads/classes, CPU, uptime, Tomcat sessions, HikariCP pool, logback events, `http.server.requests` (every MVC/WebFlux request, tagged `method`, `uri` template, `status`, `outcome`, `exception`), `http.client.requests` (for `RestClient`/`WebClient` built from Boot's builders), cache, Kafka and more.

Custom meters

From `OrderService.java`:

```java
public OrderService(MeterRegistry registry) {
    this.registry = registry;
    // A Timer records how many calls and how long they took
    this.placeTimer = Timer.builder("orders.place")
            .description("time to place an order")
            .register(registry);
    // A Gauge samples a current value on demand (here: the map size)
    registry.gauge("orders.stored", orders, Map::size);
}

@Observed(name = "order.lookup", contextualName = "order-lookup")   // see 15.6
public Optional<String> find(long id) {
    log.info("looking up order {}", id);
    Optional<String> item = Optional.ofNullable(orders.get(id));
    // A Counter only goes up; the tag splits it into one time series per result
    Counter.builder("orders.lookups")
            .tag("result", item.isPresent() ? "found" : "missing")
            .register(registry)            // returns the existing counter if already registered
            .increment();
    return item;
}

public long place(String item) {
    return placeTimer.record(() -> { /* ... store it ... */ });
}
```

Common tags for every meter come from properties:

```properties
management.metrics.tags.region=eu-west-1
# optional: publish histogram buckets so Prometheus can compute p95/p99 across instances
management.metrics.distribution.percentiles-histogram.http.server.requests=true
```

Reading metrics: `/actuator/metrics` and `/actuator/prometheus`

The test makes two successful lookups, one miss and one order, then reads both endpoints:

```
/actuator/metrics/orders.lookups -> {"availableTags":[{"tag":"result","values":["missing","found"]},
{"tag":"region","values":["eu-west-1"]}],"measurements":
[{"statistic":"COUNT","value":3.0}],"name":"orders.lookups"}
/actuator/prometheus (selected lines):
  http_server_requests_seconds_count{error="none",exception="none",method="GET",outcome="CLIENT_ERROR",region="eu-
west-1",status="404",uri="/orders/{id}"} 1
  http_server_requests_seconds_count{error="none",exception="none",method="GET",outcome="SUCCESS",region="eu-west-
1",status="200",uri="/orders/{id}"} 2
  order_lookup_seconds_count{class="ch15.obs.OrderService",error="none",method="find",region="eu-west-1"} 3
  orders_lookups_total{region="eu-west-1",result="found"} 2.0
  orders_lookups_total{region="eu-west-1",result="missing"} 1.0
  orders_place_seconds_count{region="eu-west-1"} 1
  orders_stored{region="eu-west-1"} 3.0
```

What to notice:

- `/actuator/metrics/{name}` aggregates across tags (COUNT 3.0); drill down with `?tag=result:found`.
- **Naming conventions** are translated per backend: Micrometer names use dots (`orders.lookups`); Prometheus gets `orders_lookups_total` (counter suffix), timers become `_seconds_*`.
- The `uri` tag is the **template** `/orders/{id}`, not `/orders/1` — otherwise every id would create a new time series.
- Every meter carries the common `region` tag.
- `@Observed` produced the timer `order_lookup_seconds` without any `MeterRegistry` code.

Push vs pull. Prometheus **pulls** (scrapes) `/actuator/prometheus` every 15–60 s. Other backends are **pushed** to, e.g. OTLP with `management.otlp.metrics.export.url=http://collector:4318/v1/metrics`. In `@SpringBootTest`, Boot switches metric exporters off (only an in-memory registry stays) unless the class has `@AutoConfigureMetrics` — that's why the Prometheus test uses it.

Cardinality — the one rule that matters

Cardinality = the number of distinct tag-value combinations. Each one is a separate time series stored by the monitoring system. Tags must have a **small, bounded** set of values (HTTP method, status, region, result). Never tag with user ids, order ids, emails, full URLs or timestamps — a million users means a million series, which can crash Prometheus or explode a SaaS (software-as-a-service, i.e. a hosted, pay-per-use monitoring product) bill. Put such values in **traces or logs** instead.

Common mistakes

- High-cardinality tags (see above).
- Creating a new `Timer.builder(...).register(...)` in a hot loop is fine (it returns the cached meter), but building meters with *dynamic names* is not — use tags.
- Averages for latency. Use percentiles (p95, p99: the time that 95% / 99% of requests stay under; see System Design Fundamentals) from histograms; averages hide the slow tail that users feel.
- Gauges on objects that get garbage-collected (freed automatically by the JVM once nothing uses them): `registry.gauge(name, obj, fn)` holds a **weak** reference (one that does not stop the object being freed); if nothing else holds `obj`, the gauge reports `NaN`.

Self-check

1. Counter vs gauge? → Counter only increases (rate over time); gauge is a current value that goes up and down.
2. Why does `http.server.requests` tag `uri="/orders/{id}"`? → To keep cardinality bounded — the template, not the concrete path.
3. How does Prometheus get the data? → It scrapes `/actuator/prometheus` (pull).

15.6 The Observation API and `@Observed`

What it is

An **Observation** (Micrometer 1.10+, Boot 3+) wraps a unit of work — "look up an order" — once, and **handlers** decide what to produce from it: a `Timer` (metrics handler), a span (tracing handler), a log line, or anything else. Spring's own instrumentation (MVC, WebFlux, `RestClient`, `WebClient`, JDBC via extensions, Spring Security, Kafka, `@Scheduled`...) is written this way, which is why one dependency change gives you both metrics and traces.

```
Observation.createNotStarted("order.lookup", observationRegistry)
        .lowCardinalityKeyValue("channel", "web")     // -> metric tag AND span attribute
        .highCardinalityKeyValue("orderId", "42")     // -> span attribute only
        .observe(() -> service.find(42));
```

- **Low-cardinality key values** become metric tags *and* span attributes.
- **High-cardinality key values** go only to spans (safe for ids).

`@Observed(name = "order.lookup", contextualName = "order-lookup")` on a bean method does the same through an aspect (AOP code that runs around annotated methods, Chapter 4). It needs the AspectJ starter (`spring-boot-starter-aspectj` in Boot 4) and, since Boot 3.2, the property:

```
management.observations.annotations.enabled=true   # also activates @Timed, @Counted, @NewSpan
```

The metric is named after `name` (`order.lookup` → `order_lookup_seconds_*` above, tagged `class` and `method`); the span is named after `contextualName`:

```
spans for GET /orders/2 -> [http get /orders/{id}, order-lookup]
```

Tuning which observations happen

```
# switch off whole families by name prefix
management.observations.enable.spring.security=false
# common key values added to every observation
management.observations.key-values.region=eu-west-1
```

Spring Security creates several observations per request (filter chain before/after, authentication, authorization). In the demo's first run they made up most of the exported spans; disabling the `spring.security` prefix keeps the traces readable. For finer control register an `ObservationPredicate` bean.

Context propagation. Observations live in thread-local state. For `@Async` methods on Boot's executor set `spring.task.execution.propagate-context=true` (or register a `ContextPropagatingTaskDecorator` on your own executor); for Reactor use `spring.reactor.context-propagation=auto`.

Self-check

1. Low vs high cardinality key values? → Low go to metrics and spans; high only to spans.
2. What must you add for `@Observed` to work? → AspectJ starter + `management.observations.annotations.enabled=true`.

15.7 Distributed tracing

What it is

A **trace** follows one request across every service it touches. It is a tree of **spans**; each span is one timed operation (an incoming HTTP request, an outgoing call, a DB query) with a **span id**, the **trace id** shared by the whole tree, a **parent span id**, start/end time and attributes.

Analogy: a parcel tracking number. Every depot that handles the parcel scans the same number (trace id) and adds its own entry (span) with arrival and departure times.

How it works

1. A request arrives without trace headers → the server observation starts a **root span** with a new 128-bit trace id.
2. The trace context is stored in the current thread and copied into the log MDC (`traceId`, `spanId`).
3. An outgoing call through an instrumented client (Boot's `RestClient.Builder`, `WebClient.Builder`, `RestTemplateBuilder`, Kafka templates...) creates a **client span** and injects the context into headers — by default the **W3C Trace Context** header (a web standard from the W3C, the body behind HTML and CSS) `traceparent: 00-<traceId>-<spanId>-01`.
4. The downstream service reads the header and continues the same trace with a child span.
5. Finished spans go to a **span processor** → **exporter** (OTLP to a collector, Zipkin, ...). Boot batches them (`BatchSpanProcessor`).
6. The backend (Tempo, Jaeger, Zipkin) stitches spans by trace id into a timeline.

Sampling decides which traces are recorded: `management.tracing.sampling.probability` (default **0.1** = 10%). The decision is made at the root and travels in the header, so a trace is either complete or absent.

Setup in Boot 4

```
<!-- Micrometer Tracing + OpenTelemetry bridge + OTLP exporters -->
<dependency>
  <groupId>org.springframework.boot</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry</artifactId>
</dependency>
<!-- tests: spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry-test (provides @AutoConfigureTracing) -->
```

```
management.tracing.sampling.probability=1.0     # 100% in dev/test; lower in high-traffic prod
# send spans to an OpenTelemetry Collector (not used in the demo - no collector running)
# management.opentelemetry.tracing.export.otlp.endpoint=http://otel-collector:4318/v1/traces
```

The Brave/Zipkin alternative is `spring-boot-starter-zipkin` with `management.tracing.export.zipkin.endpoint`. Boot 3 users: the dependency used to be `micrometer-tracing-bridge-otel` + `opentelemetry-exporter-otlp`; the one starter replaces both.

A "logging exporter" instead of a collector

To see spans without running Jaeger, the demo registers its own `SpanExporter` bean; Boot adds every `SpanExporter` bean to its batch processor:

```
@Component
public class PrintingSpanExporter implements SpanExporter {
    private final List<SpanData> finished = new CopyOnWriteArrayList<>();

    @Override
    public CompletableResultCode export(Collection<SpanData> spans) {
        finished.addAll(spans);                       // a real exporter would send them over OTLP
        return CompletableResultCode.ofSuccess();
    }
    // ... flush(), shutdown(), finished(), clear()
}
```

The controller calls a second endpoint over HTTP with Boot's `RestClient.Builder`, standing in for a downstream service:

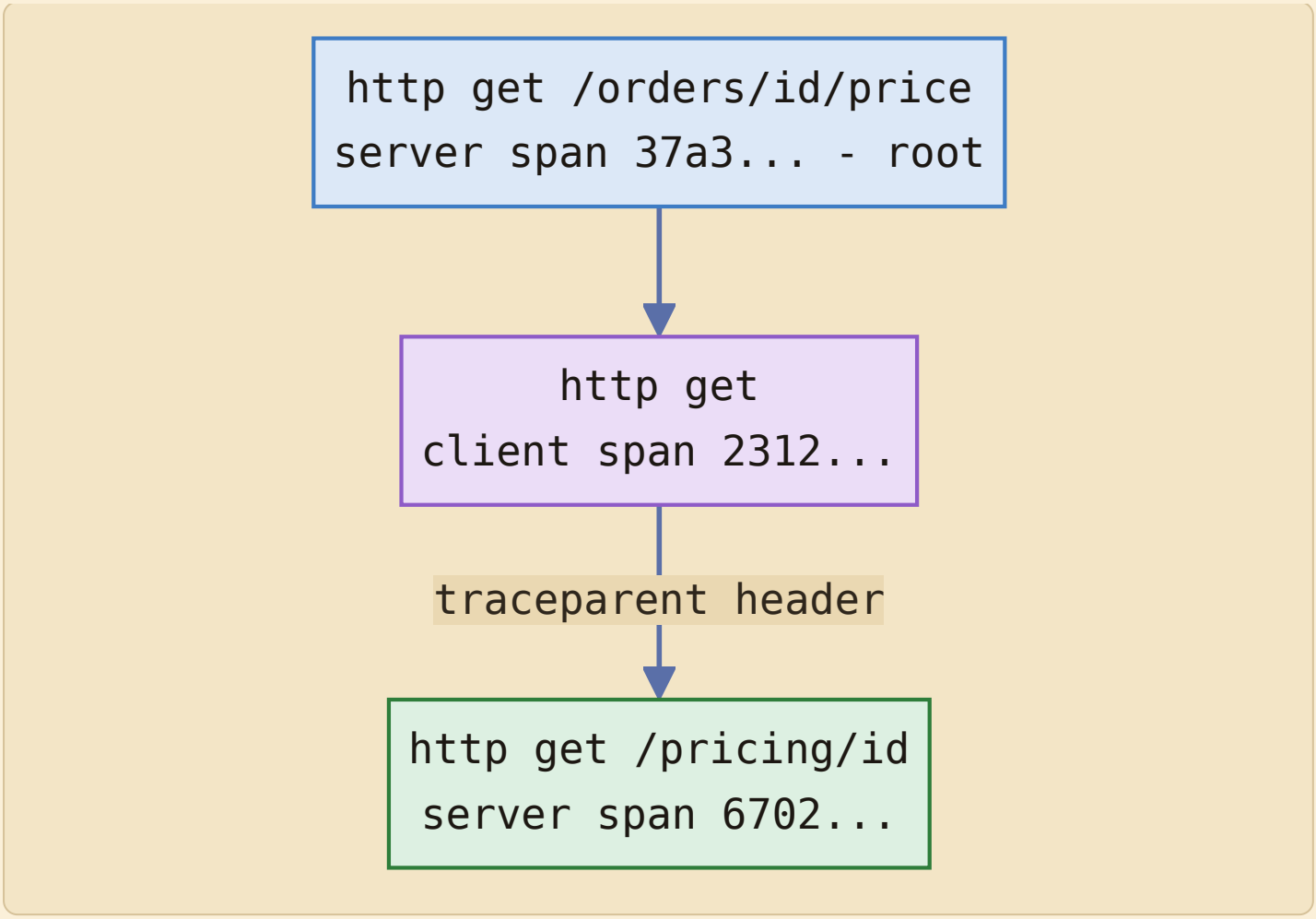
```
@GetMapping("/orders/{id}/price")
public String price(@PathVariable long id) {
    log.info("asking pricing service for order {}", id);
    String base = "http://localhost:" + env.getProperty("local.server.port");
    return restClientBuilder.build().get()
            .uri(base + "/pricing/{id}", id)
            .retrieve().body(String.class);
}

@GetMapping("/pricing/{id}")
public String pricing(@PathVariable long id) {
    log.info("pricing order {}", id);
    return "price for " + id + " = 49.99";
}
```

`TracingTests` (with `@AutoConfigureTracing`, because tests disable span export by default) calls `/orders/1/price`, flushes the batch processor and prints the log lines and spans:

```
response: price for 1 = 49.99
log lines (trace id - span id in brackets):
  [orders] [o-auto-1-exec-8] [89fb1d6934d0cf54e0910695a8df7859-37a3311dfdcc61c3] ch15.obs.OrderController
: asking pricing service for order 1
  [orders] [o-auto-1-exec-9] [89fb1d6934d0cf54e0910695a8df7859-6702c6550d5a9bfd] ch15.obs.OrderController
: pricing order 1
finished spans:
  http get /orders/{id}/price  trace=89fb1d6934d0cf54e0910695a8df7859 span=37a3311dfdcc61c3
parent=0000000000000000
  http get                     trace=89fb1d6934d0cf54e0910695a8df7859 span=2312285359b3b845
parent=37a3311dfdcc61c3
  http get /pricing/{id}       trace=89fb1d6934d0cf54e0910695a8df7859 span=6702c6550d5a9bfd
parent=2312285359b3b845
```

Read it as a tree:



- Two different Tomcat threads (`exec-8`, `exec-9`) logged with the **same trace id** — that is propagation through the `traceparent` header.
- Each log line's span id matches the span that was active (`37a3...` for the outer request, `6702...` for the downstream one).
- Boot's default console pattern prints `[application-name] [thread] [traceId-spanId]`; change it with `logging.pattern.correlation`.
- Across *real* services the picture is identical; only the exporter sends the spans to a shared backend.

Baggage is extra key/value context that travels with the trace (e.g. a tenant id): `management.tracing.baggage.remote-fields=tenant` sends it in headers, `management.tracing.baggage.correlation.fields=tenant` also puts it in the MDC.

Trade-offs

Choice	Pro	Con
Sampling 100%	every request traceable	CPU, network and storage cost at scale
Head sampling (e.g. 10%, Boot default)	cheap, simple	the rare failing request is often not sampled
Tail sampling in the OTel Collector	keep all errors/slow traces, drop the rest	collector must buffer whole traces
OTel **Java agent** (a jar attached at JVM start that instruments classes automatically) instead of Micrometer	zero code, instruments many libraries	a second instrumentation layer; version coupling with the JVM agent

Common mistakes

- Building `RestClient.builder()` / `new RestTemplate()` yourself → no instrumentation, the trace breaks at that hop. Inject Boot's builder.
- Losing context on your own thread pools or `CompletableFuture` → wrap executors with context propagation.
- Using trace ids as metric tags → cardinality explosion.
- Sampling 1.0 in a busy production system without a plan for storage.

In the interview

Q: How does distributed tracing work in Spring Boot? 30-second answer: Micrometer Observation instruments incoming and outgoing calls; Micrometer Tracing with the OpenTelemetry (or Brave) bridge turns observations into spans. A trace id is created at the edge, propagated in the W3C `traceparent` header by instrumented clients, and put in the log MDC. Spans are batched and exported via OTLP to a collector and viewed in Tempo/Jaeger/Zipkin. Sampling defaults to 10%.

- *Follow-up: why is my trace broken between two services?* → The client isn't instrumented (created with `new`), a proxy strips headers, the propagation format differs (W3C vs B3, Zipkin's older header format), or async code lost the context.
- *Follow-up: logs vs traces?* → Traces show timing and causality across services; logs give detail within one; the shared trace id links them.

Self-check

1. What header carries the context by default? → W3C `traceparent`.
2. Default sampling probability? → 0.1.
3. What is a parent span id of `0000000000000000`? → A root span (no parent).

TL;DR

`spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry` + `management.tracing.sampling.probability`; inject Boot's client builders; trace/span ids appear in logs automatically; export via `management.opentelemetry.tracing.export.otlp.endpoint`.

15.8 Structured logging

What it is

Structured logging writes each event as a machine-readable record (JSON) instead of a formatted line. Log platforms (Elasticsearch/Kibana, Loki, Graylog, Datadog, Cloud Logging) can then filter on fields — `log.level:ERROR AND service.name:orders AND traceId:...` — instead of parsing text with regexes (regular expressions: text-matching patterns). Built into Boot since **3.4**.

```
logging.structured.format.console=ecs        # ecs | logstash | gelf
logging.structured.format.file=logstash      # file output can use a different format
logging.structured.ecs.service.version=1.0.0
logging.structured.ecs.service.environment=test
```

Format	Standard	Typical destination
`ecs`	Elastic Common Schema	Elasticsearch / Elastic Agent, also fine for Loki
`logstash`	Logstash JSON	Logstash, Fluentd/Fluent Bit
`gelf`	Graylog Extended Log Format	Graylog

`StructuredLoggingTests` starts the app with `ecs` and captures the log line of one request:

```
ECS log line:
{"@timestamp":"2026-09-28T23:50:30.319867Z","log":{"level":"INFO","logger":"ch15.obs.OrderService"},"process":
{"pid":17381,"thread":{"name":"http-nio-auto-2-exec-1"}},"service":
{"name":"orders","version":"1.0.0","environment":"test","node":{}},"message":"looking up order
1","traceId":"636cb6141b8e904e29a6f7824c3eb713","spanId":"8ceaaf80e43135b1","ecs":{"version":"8.11"}}
```

`service.name` comes from `spring.application.name`; all MDC entries — here `traceId` and `spanId` from the tracer — become fields automatically, as do key/values from SLF4J's fluent API (`log.atInfo().addKeyValue("orderId", id).log("placed")`).

Customise the JSON without code:

```
logging.structured.json.exclude=process.pid
logging.structured.json.rename.process.thread.name=thread
logging.structured.json.add.team=checkout
logging.structured.json.stacktrace.root=first          # root cause first
logging.structured.json.stacktrace.max-throwable-depth=20
```

For full control implement `StructuredLogFormatter<ILoggingEvent>` and name the class in `logging.structured.format.console`.

When not to use it: local development in a terminal — JSON is hard for humans to read. A common setup is plain text by default and JSON in the `prod` profile (`application-prod.properties`), or JSON to a file and text to the console.

Common mistakes: logging secrets or personal data (JSON makes them *easier* to search — mask them); multi-line stack traces in text logs that the shipper (the agent that collects log output and sends it to the log platform) splits into many events (JSON keeps them in one field); logging at DEBUG in production for hot paths (cost and noise). The demo also shows a practical catch: the logging system is global to the JVM, so the structured-logging test runs last (`junit-platform.properties` orders the classes).

15.9 Graceful shutdown

What it is

When an instance is stopped (a deployment, scale-down, node drain — moving everything off a machine before maintenance), requests that are **in flight** should finish instead of failing. **Graceful shutdown** stops accepting new connections, waits for active requests up to a timeout, then stops. It is the **default since Boot 3.4** for Tomcat, Jetty and Reactor Netty (`server.shutdown=graceful`); `server.shutdown=immediate` turns it off.

```
spring.lifecycle.timeout-per-shutdown-phase=10s   # default 30s
```

How it works

1. The JVM receives `SIGTERM` — the operating system's polite "please stop" signal, sent by Kubernetes and `docker stop` (Ctrl+C sends the similar `SIGINT`); unlike `SIGKILL` it lets the JVM run its shutdown hooks → Spring's shutdown hook closes the application context.
2. Readiness switches to `REFUSING_TRAFFIC`.
3. The web server's lifecycle bean stops first: it stops accepting new connections at the network level and waits for active requests.
4. When they finish (or the timeout expires), the rest of the context closes: `@PreDestroy`, connection pools, executors.

Proof

`GracefulShutdownTests` starts the app, begins a request to `/slow?ms=1000`, closes the context while it runs (as `SIGTERM` would), and tries a new request 200 ms later — once with each mode:

```
ConfigurableApplicationContext ctx = SpringApplication.run(RuntimeApplication.class,
        "--server.port=0", "--server.shutdown=" + shutdownMode, "--spring.main.banner-mode=off");
// ... start a 1-second request, wait until it is inside the controller ...
Thread closer = Thread.ofPlatform().start(ctx::close);        // like SIGTERM from Kubernetes
Thread.sleep(200);
// ... try a new request, then wait for both ...
```

```
server.shutdown=immediate in-flight -> FAILED: IOException | new request during shutdown -> rejected
(ConnectException) | close took < 0.7 s (did not wait)
server.shutdown=graceful  in-flight -> HTTP 200 'done after 1000 ms' | new request during shutdown -> rejected
(ConnectException) | close took ~1 s (waited)
  log: Commencing graceful shutdown. Waiting for active requests to complete
  log: Graceful shutdown complete
```

In Kubernetes

There is a race: Kubernetes sends `SIGTERM` and removes the pod from the Service endpoints **at the same time**, and load balancers may still send new requests for a few seconds. Since the server refuses new connections immediately, add a short delay before shutdown starts:

```
spec:
  terminationGracePeriodSeconds: 45          # must exceed preStop + Spring timeout
  containers:
    - name: orders
      lifecycle:
        preStop:
          sleep: { seconds: 10 }             # K8s 1.30+; older: exec ["sh","-c","sleep 10"]
```

Common mistakes

- `timeout-per-shutdown-phase` longer than Kubernetes' `terminationGracePeriodSeconds` (default 30 s) → the pod is `SIGKILL`ed mid-drain.
- Expecting graceful shutdown to finish **message consumers** or `@Async` jobs — configure those separately (listener container stop, `spring.task.execution.shutdown.await-termination=true`).
- Running from an IDE that kills the process instead of sending SIGTERM (then shutdown looks immediate).

Self-check

1. Is graceful shutdown on by default? → Yes, since Boot 3.4.
2. What happens to new requests during the grace period? → They are refused at the network layer (connection refused), not answered with 503.
3. Why a `preStop` sleep? → To let endpoint removal propagate before the server stops accepting connections.

15.10 Virtual threads

Virtual threads (final in Java 21, Java book 15.4) are cheap threads managed by the JVM; a blocked virtual thread releases its carrier OS thread. For blocking servlet apps this raises the number of concurrent requests you can hold without a huge thread pool. In Boot (3.2+) one property switches them on:

```
spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true
```

It makes Tomcat/Jetty run each request on a virtual thread and switches Boot's auto-configured `@Async` executor, `@Scheduled` scheduler and several messaging listener containers to virtual threads (the `@Async` side is shown in 14.5). `VirtualThreadsTests` calls an endpoint that reports `Thread.currentThread()`:

```
spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true  -> virtual thread: VirtualThread[#100,tomcat-handler-
0]/runnable@ForkJoinPool-1-worker-1
default                              -> platform thread: Thread[#108,http-nio-auto-4-exec-1,5,main]
```

Caveats.

- Your **bottleneck** (the one slowest part that limits the whole system) **moves**: 10,000 concurrent requests now reach the database pool (10 connections by default) or a downstream API. Limit concurrency explicitly — `@ConcurrencyLimit` (4.7), pool sizes, bulkheads.
- Pinning: before JDK 24, blocking inside `synchronized` pinned the carrier thread; JDK 24 (JEP 491) removed that for `synchronized`. Native calls can still pin.
- Virtual threads are daemon threads: an app whose only work is `@Scheduled` tasks may exit; set `spring.main.keep-alive=true`.
- CPU-bound work gains nothing. Virtual threads vs reactive: see Chapter 13.

15.11 Faster startup: extracted jars, CDS, AOT cache, native images

The problem it solves

A typical Boot app takes 1–5 s to start on the JVM (class loading, reflection, bean creation, JIT warm-up). That matters for autoscaling (adding and removing instances automatically with load), serverless (scale-to-zero: no instance runs until a request arrives) and fast rollbacks (returning to the previous version). Options, from least to most invasive:

Technique	What it does	Startup gain	Cost
Extracted jar	run from unpacked `lib/` instead of nested jars	small	a build step
CDS (Class Data Sharing; application classes since JDK 10, dynamic archives since JDK 13)	archive of parsed classes from a training run (a short run of the app whose only purpose is to record what it loads)	~20–40%	training run, same JDK/classpath
JDK AOT cache (JEP 483 in JDK 24, simpler flags JEP 514 and method profiles JEP 515 in JDK 25)	caches classes *loaded and linked* (plus profiles) from a training run	often ~2×	training run; cache tied to the JDK build and exact jars
Spring AOT on the JVM	generates bean-definition code at build time (`spring-boot:process-aot`), run with `-Dspring.aot.enabled=true`	modest	profiles/conditions fixed at build time
GraalVM native image	compiles the whole app ahead of time to a native executable	~50–100× (tens of ms)	long builds, closed-world limits, reflection hints, lower peak throughput (maximum requests per second) without PGO (profile-guided optimisation)

Measured: AOT cache on JDK 25

`aot-cache-demo.sh` builds `production-runtime`, extracts it and times start-until-context-refreshed (`-Dspring.context.exit=onRefresh` exits right after the context refresh, a Framework 6.1+ feature made for training runs):

```
java -Djarmode=tools -jar target/app.jar extract --destination target/app   # app jar + lib/
cd target/app
# training run: record and write the cache in one step (JDK 25)
java -XX:AOTCacheOutput=app.aot -Dspring.context.exit=onRefresh -jar app.jar
# production run
java -XX:AOTCache=app.aot -jar app.jar
```

Run it as `bash aot-cache-demo.sh <JDK-25-home>` (the script otherwise uses `$JAVA_HOME`). Rows 2 and 3 are the median of 5 runs. Output on this machine (Apple silicon laptop, Homebrew OpenJDK 25.0.2; **timings are machine-dependent** — measure your own):

```
java: openjdk version "25.0.2" 2026-01-20
1. fat jar (java -jar)               : 1152 ms (mean of 3)
2. extracted jar                     : 934 ms
   AOT cache file                    :  56M
3. extracted jar + -XX:AOTCache      : 467 ms
```

The AOT cache cut JVM-to-context-ready time by more than half for this small web app, at the price of a 56 MB file and a training step in the build. For CDS on JDK 13–24 the equivalent flags are `-XX:ArchiveClassesAtExit=app.jsa` (training) and `-XX:SharedArchiveFile=app.jsa`. The cache is only valid for the same JDK build and the same jars; if they differ, the JVM ignores it (with a warning) and starts normally.

GraalVM native image (not run — `native-image` is not installed here)

```
# needs GraalVM / Liberica NIK 25; spring-boot-starter-parent provides the "native" profile
mvn -Pnative native:compile          # -> target/<artifactId>, a native executable
mvn -Pnative spring-boot:build-image # same, inside a container image (needs Docker)
```

Plus the `org.graalvm.buildtools:native-maven-plugin` in the POM (`pom.xml`, Maven's project file). The build runs Spring AOT, then GraalVM analyses everything reachable from `main` (**closed world**): classes not seen at build time cannot be loaded later; reflection, resources, proxies and serialization need **hints** (Spring generates most; add your own with `RuntimeHintsRegistrar` or `@RegisterReflectionForBinding`). Profiles and `@ConditionalOnProperty` are evaluated at build time. Test the native build in CI (`mvn -PnativeTest test`) because some libraries fail only there.

Choose native for CLIs (command-line tools), functions (small serverless handlers), scale-to-zero services and memory-tight deployments. **Stay on the JVM** (with the AOT cache) for long-running, throughput-heavy services, where the JIT's peak performance and easy debugging win.

Container images (not run — Docker is not running here)

Cloud Native **Buildpacks** turn the jar into an **OCI image** (the standard container-image format that Docker and Kubernetes run) with no Dockerfile:

```
mvn spring-boot:build-image -Dspring-boot.build-image.imageName=acme/orders:1.0
# JVM options for the buildpack, e.g. enable the AOT cache or CDS training at build time:
#   <env><BP_JVM_AOTCACHE_ENABLED>true</BP_JVM_AOTCACHE_ENABLED></env>   (or BP_JVM_CDS_ENABLED)
```

Or a layered Dockerfile (the recipe file Docker builds an image from; each instruction creates a cached layer) — dependencies change rarely, so they go in their own layer and are cached between builds:

```dockerfile
FROM eclipse-temurin:25-jre AS build
WORKDIR /build
COPY target/orders.jar app.jar
RUN java -Djarmode=tools -jar app.jar extract --layers --destination out

FROM eclipse-temurin:25-jre
WORKDIR /app
COPY --from=build /build/out/dependencies/ ./
COPY --from=build /build/out/spring-boot-loader/ ./
COPY --from=build /build/out/snapshot-dependencies/ ./
COPY --from=build /build/out/application/ ./
RUN java -XX:AOTCacheOutput=app.aot -Dspring.context.exit=onRefresh -jar app.jar
USER 1000
ENTRYPOINT ["java", "-XX:AOTCache=app.aot", "-XX:MaxRAMPercentage=75", "-jar", "app.jar"]
```

`-XX:MaxRAMPercentage` sizes the heap from the container's memory limit; running as a non-root user (not the all-powerful administrator account) is a basic hardening (reducing attack surface) step.

Self-check

1. What does `-Dspring.context.exit=onRefresh` do? → Starts the app until the context is refreshed, then exits — used for AOT cache / CDS training runs.
2. AOT cache vs native image? → AOT cache keeps the JVM and JIT, speeds startup by reusing loaded/linked classes; native image compiles to a standalone executable with much faster startup but closed-world constraints.
3. Why extract the jar first? → The AOT cache/CDS need a plain classpath of jars; nested jars in the fat jar (the single jar Boot builds, with all dependency jars packed inside) are not cache-friendly.

15.12 Production configuration checklist

Area	Setting / practice
Actuator exposure	expose only what you use (`health,info,prometheus`); protect the rest with `EndpointRequest`; consider `management.server.port`
Health	probes (on by default in Boot 4) wired to Kubernetes; custom indicators fast; no dependencies in liveness
Metrics	Prometheus or OTLP registry; common tags (`application`, `region`); histograms for latency SLOs (service level objectives: targets such as "p99 under 300 ms"); bounded tag values
Tracing	`spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry`; sampling rate chosen consciously; OTLP endpoint to a collector
Logging	structured JSON in prod profile; levels INFO/WARN; no secrets or personal data; change levels at runtime via `/actuator/loggers`
Shutdown	graceful (default) + `timeout-per-shutdown-phase` < K8s grace period; `preStop` delay
Threads	`spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true` for blocking I/O apps, with explicit concurrency limits
Startup	extracted jar + AOT cache (JDK 25) or native image where startup matters
Config & secrets	externalised config per environment (Chapter 3); secrets from a vault or K8s secrets, never in the jar
Resources	container memory limit + `MaxRAMPercentage`; connection pool sized to the database
Errors	`spring.web.error.include-stacktrace=never` (default; Boot 4 name — the old `server.error.*` keys are no longer bound since 4.0.0) and Problem Details (Chapter 5)

15.13 Common mistakes (whole chapter)

Symptom	Cause	Fix
`/actuator/prometheus` returns 404	registry dependency missing or endpoint not exposed	add `micrometer-registry-prometheus`, include `prometheus` in exposure
Prometheus endpoint missing only in tests	Boot disables metric export in tests	`@AutoConfigureMetrics`
No trace ids in logs	no tracer on the classpath, or a custom log pattern without `%X{traceId}`	add `spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry`; keep Boot's correlation pattern
Trace breaks between services	client created with `new` / `builder()`	inject Boot's `RestClient.Builder` / `WebClient.Builder`
`@Observed` does nothing	property or AspectJ starter missing, or self-invocation	`management.observations.annotations.enabled=true`, `spring-boot-starter-aspectj`, call through the proxy
Prometheus memory explodes	high-cardinality tags	remove ids from tags
Pods restart during DB outage	DB in liveness	keep liveness internal
502s (Bad Gateway: the proxy got no valid answer from the app) during deployments	no `preStop` delay, grace timeout too short	`preStop` sleep, align timeouts
Secrets visible in `/actuator/env`	`show-values=always`	leave the default `never`, secure the endpoint

---

15.14 In the interview

Q: What is Spring Boot Actuator and how do you secure it? Management endpoints (health, info, metrics, prometheus, loggers, env, ...). Only `health` is exposed by default; expose more with `management.endpoints.web.exposure.include`, restrict with `management.endpoint.<id>.access`, and secure with a `SecurityFilterChain` using `EndpointRequest.to(...)` / `toAnyEndpoint()`, often on a separate management port.

- *Follow-up: how would you change a log level in production without redeploying?* → `POST /actuator/loggers/<logger>` with `{"configuredLevel":"DEBUG"}` (protected endpoint).

Q: Counter, Gauge, Timer — when to use which? → Counter for events that accumulate (rate via PromQL, Prometheus's query language, `rate()`), Gauge for current values (queue depth), Timer for durations (count/sum/max/histogram → latency percentiles). Keep tags low-cardinality.

Q: What does the Observation API add over plain Micrometer metrics? → Instrument once, get metrics *and* traces (and custom handlers); Spring's own instrumentation uses it; `@Observed` for methods.

Q: How does a trace id get from service A to B? → The instrumented HTTP client injects `traceparent`; B's server observation extracts it and creates a child span; both log the same trace id via MDC.

Q: How do you do zero-downtime deployments (releasing a new version without any moment of unavailability) with Spring Boot on Kubernetes? → Readiness probe (Boot marks ready after startup), graceful shutdown (default), `preStop` delay, grace period longer than the drain timeout, rolling update with `maxUnavailable: 0`. See blue-green and canary.

Q: How would you speed up startup? → Lazy init (create beans only when first used) where safe, fewer auto-configurations, extracted jar + CDS/AOT cache (JDK 25: `-XX:AOTCacheOutput` training, `-XX:AOTCache`), Spring AOT, or GraalVM native image — trading build complexity and closed-world limits for startup.

Q: Virtual threads in Spring Boot? → `spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true` (Java 21+, Boot 3.2+); great for blocking I/O; move concurrency limits to explicit places (pools, `@ConcurrencyLimit`).

Chapter TL;DR

- Observability = **logs + metrics + traces**, linked by the trace id. Spring: Logback, **Micrometer**, **Micrometer Tracing + OpenTelemetry**, all fed by the **Observation API**.
- **Actuator**: only `health` exposed by default; control with `exposure.include` and `access`; secure with `EndpointRequest` (Boot 4 package `org.springframework.boot.security.autoconfigure.actuate.web.servlet`).
- **Health**: `HealthIndicator` (Boot 4 package `org.springframework.boot.health.contributor`), groups, **liveness/readiness on by default in Boot 4**; DOWN → 503; no external deps in liveness.
- **Metrics**: Counter/Timer/Gauge with **low-cardinality** tags; `/actuator/prometheus` for scraping; `@AutoConfigureMetrics` in tests.
- **Observation / `@Observed`**: one instrumentation → timer + span; needs `management.observations.annotations.enabled=true` + AspectJ.
- **Tracing**: `spring-boot-starter-opentelemetry`; W3C `traceparent` propagation via Boot's client builders; `[traceId-spanId]` in logs; sampling default 0.1; export over OTLP.
- **Structured logging** (Boot 3.4+): `logging.structured.format.console=ecs|logstash|gelf`; MDC fields included.
- **Graceful shutdown** is the default (Boot 3.4+); tune `spring.lifecycle.timeout-per-shutdown-phase`; add a `preStop` delay on Kubernetes.
- **Virtual threads**: `spring.threads.virtual.enabled=true`.
- **Startup**: extract the jar, train an **AOT cache** (JDK 25; 934 → 467 ms here), or build a **GraalVM native image**; package with buildpacks or a layered Dockerfile.
- Next: Chapter 16 — Spring Cloud and Microservices.